Alabama Learning Hour

Ava's Animals: Possession Class 2

October 29, 2026

1 *Ava innaasi iyyi ostaakaha*

Ava innaasi iyyi ostaakaha

Ava's animals - Alabama Text

naasi iyyi ostaaka ava imiisafa lahwahchi.
iisahayon kati lochan, ifa hatkak iisahchi.
achan akaakak tałłaapin, aayampo kolokbifan łałok nampobi.
ya łałok laanahchi, ahki łałok okchakkohchi.
chassi imiisafan chichobon hiichali?
oh, waakoolo.
Avak hachonchoban bannati, maamin taatak waakan choopati.
ittofan sawak wiikahchi.
sawak Avan imbiniilihchi.
stanooko!

Ava's animals - English translation

There are a lot of animals at Ava's home.
In the house, a black cat and a white dog live.
Outside, there are five chickens, and in the bowl, there are many fish.
This fish is yellow, that fish is green.
Do I see a horse in the barn?
No, it is a cow.
Ava wanted an aligator, but dad bought a cow.
In a tree, the raccoon lives.
The raccoon visits Ava.
the end!

2 Vocabulary

Nouns

naasi iyyi ostaaka	animal
iisa	house
kati	cat
ifa	dog
akaaka	chicken
aayampo	dish
kolokbi	deep hole
aayampo kolokbi	bowl
łałło	fish
chassi imiisa	barn
chassi	corn
chichoba	horse
waaka	cow
hachonchoba	alligator
hachi	tail
choba	big
taata	dad
itto	tree
sawa	raccoon

Verbs

lahwa	to be many, a lot
nampo	to be many
iisa	to live at a place
hiicha	to see
banna	to want
choopa	to buy
wiika	to stay, be, live
imbiniili	to visit
anooka	to be gone, finished up

Adjectives

locha	black
hatka	white
laana	yellow
okchakko	green

Other

acha	outside
taɬɬaapi	five
ya	this
ahki	that
maamin	but, however
stanooko	the end

3 Possession

- Last week we began to learn about *possession*
  - e.g. *my cat*, *your cat*
- To talk about *possession*, nouns need little pieces on the beginning to indicate who they belong to. We learned the difference between the **Possessor** (the one who possess) and the **Possesse** (that which is possessed)

(1)

my	**friend**
POSSESSOR	POSSESSEE

- In Alabama, there are two separate set of prefixes used for different nouns.

(2)

am	+ **okla**
my	+ friend
POSSESSOR	

(3)

cha	+ **holchifa**
my	+ name
POSSESSSOR	

- Most nouns take *am*-Possessors (II), but some nouns, which often express kinship terms and body parts, take *cha*-Possessors (I)—they need to be remembered. Here are some of them:

Some nouns that take *cha*-Possessors (I)

- **ifoni** ‘sister (of a man)’
- **halki** ‘wife’
- **ochoosi** ‘son, child’
- **ostayki** ‘daughter’
- **hachi** ‘tail’
- **hissi** ‘hair’
- **iyyi** ‘foot’
- **sakba** ‘arm’

Recall we learned how to talk about possession for three types of possessor types **me, you,** and **third person**.

(4) [**cha** + **Noun**]
my

(5) [**chi** + **Noun**]
your

- To say that this type of noun belongs to some third person (Ava, the child, dad), we just put two nouns together:

(6) [POSSESSOR + **Noun**]

(7) [Ava + **hissi**]
Ava's **hair**

Note: if the word starts with [i] or [o], they will disappear; e.g. *ifoni* → *cha-foni*

- Now let's try putting these nouns into a sentence.

(8) [**my/your-noun**]-**k** [**my/your-noun**]-**n** hiicha-ti
-SUBJECT -OBJECT see-PAST

(9) **cha-foni-k** **chi-hachi-n** hiicha-ti
my-sister-SUBJECT your-tail-OBJECT see-PAST
'My sister saw your tail.'

Let's practice! *How would you say the following in Alabama?*

(10) a. My sister saw your ear.
b. Your sister saw my ear.

(11) a. Your wife saw my head.
b. My wife saw your head.

(12) a. My son saw your nose.
b. Your son saw my nose.

(13) a. Your daughter saw my arm.
b. My daughter saw your arm.

- **hakcho** 'ear'
- **isbakko** 'head'
- **sakba** 'arm'
- **ibisaani** 'nose'
- **ifoni** 'sister'
- **halki** 'wife'
- **ochoosi** 'child, son'
- **ochoosi** 'child, son'
- **ostayki** 'daughter'

- If a noun is *not* on the special list, it takes an *am*-Possessor (type 2).
- We will say "my noun" by adding prefix *am-* to the noun, and we will say "your noun" by adding the prefix *chim-*. Note that *chim-* implies that you are addressing only one person.

Note: You can check which possession type a noun takes by checking the dictionary.

(14) [**am** + **Noun**]
my

(15) [**chim** + **Noun**]
your

- To say that this type of noun belongs to some third person (Ava, the child, dad), we put two nouns together:

(16) [POSSESSOR + **im-Noun**]
his/her

(17) [Ava + **im-hissi**]
Ava **'s-hair**

- Notice that all these little pieces we add end in [m]: *am-, chim-, im-*. When [m] is followed by a vowel ([i], [a], [o]), it is easy to pronounce.
- But when [m] is followed by a consonant—in particular, sounds like [t], [ch], [n], or [k], pronouncing two sounds in a row is a bit difficult. To help the speakers, Alabama changes [m] → [n] in such cases. For example:

(18) a. my basket: am + kolbi → a**n**-kolbi
b. my cornbread: am + chakaawa → a**n**-chakaawa
c. my man: am + naani → a**n**-naani
d. my flour: am + tilko → a**n**-tilko

Let's practice! *How would you say the following in Alabama?*

okla 'friend'

(19) a. my friend
b. your friend
c. Jacob's friend

taata 'dad'

(20) a. my dad
b. your dad
c. Jackson's dad

iisa ‘house’

(21) a. my house
b. your house
c. Romi’s house

kati ‘cat’

(22) a. my cat
b. your cat
c. Deb’s cat

ifa ‘dog’

(23) a. my dog
b. your dog
c. baby’s (*aatosi*) dog

chassi ‘corn’

(24) a. my corn
b. your corn
c. Nicla’s corn

akaaka ‘chicken’

(25) a. my chicken
b. your chicken
c. dad’s (*taata*) chicken

naaɬiika ‘language’

(26) a. my language
b. your language
c. Ava’s language

- Now let’s try putting these nouns into a sentence.

(27) [**my/your-noun**]-**k** [**my/your-noun**]-**n** hiicha-ti
-SUBJECT -OBJECT see-PAST

(28) **am-okla-k** **chim-ifa-n** hiicha-ti
my-sister-SUBJECT your-tail-OBJECT see-PAST
‘My friend saw your dog.’

Let’s practice! *How would you say the following in Alabama?*

(29) a. My cat saw your dog.
b. Your cat saw my dog.

(30) a. My dad saw your corn.
b. Your dad saw my corn.

(31) a. My chicken saw your house.
b. Your chicken saw my house.

(32) a. My friend saw your language.
b. Your friend saw my language.

- Another time we will learn how to say that something is “our”, “y’alls”’, and “their”.

4 Talking about myself: *What did I do yesterday?*

- So far, we have been using verbs to talk about what *someone else* is doing.
- Of course, we can use verbs to talk about more situations: what *I* have done, what *you* have done, what *we* have done, and what *ya'll* have done.
- The remaining session will focus on how Alabama changes its verb to talk about what *I* have done. We have covered a lot today, so we will discuss the other situations anotehr time.
- In many languages, verbs tell us who their arguments are. Consider:

(33) I dance. I **am** happy.

(34) Ava dance**s**. Ava **is** happy.

- This process is called **agreement**. The verb *agrees* with the subject in English, and shows us what kind of an individual it refers to.
- Agreement on the verb also appears in Alabama.
- To talk about myself, you need to **add -li** between the verb and the tense marker.

Agent Verb Sentence in Past Tense *-ti/hchõ* Easy Recipe for "I"

(35) **Statement**

[(**anok**)] [**Verb** + **-li** + **-ti**].

*(Anok) bitli-**li**-ti.* *Piyaaka (anok) bitli-**li**-ti.*

'I danced'. 'Yesterday I danced'.

(36) **Question**

[(**anok**)] [**Verb** + **-li** + **-hchõ**]?

*(Anok) bitli-**li**-hchõ?* *Piyaaka (anok) bitli-**li**-hchõ?*

'Did I dance?' 'Did I dance yesterday'?

- When the subject of a sentence is a speaker ('I'), we can use the word *anok*.

- Unlike in English, using the subject is optional in Alabama when it refers to the speaker
  - The *-li* on the verb tells us it is "I" who is doing the action!

Let's recall what "I" did yesterday! *How would you say this in Alabama?*

(37) Q: Did I laugh yesterday?
A: Yes, I laughed yesterday.

(38) Q: Did I dance yesterday?
A: Yes, I danced yesterday.

(39) Q: Did I walk yesterday?
A: Yes, I walked.

(40) Q: Did I drink yesterday?
A: Yes, I drank.

(41) Q: Did I jump yesterday?
A: Yes, I jumped yesterday.

(42) Q: Did I swim yesterday?
A: Yes, I swam yesterday.

Verbs

- **afaaka** 'to laugh'
- **isko** 'to drink'
- **bitli** 'to dance'
- **chiyahli** 'to walk'
- **ilakomayli** 'to swim'
- **choffi** 'to jump'

- Now let's review the text to see the new pieces we can recognize!